

Chapter

The Hidden Meaning of Symbols — Scripture and Guru



Introduction: Why Do the Scriptures Speak in Symbols?

Our scriptures are full of stories, metaphors and symbols. The question arises — why is the truth not simply stated outright? Acharya Upendra Ji answers this question with a simple observation:

"Why is it said in symbols? Because the real shastra (body of knowledge) the teacher has to teach is very **gūḍha** — it is deep."

Gūḍha — meaning profound, hidden, something that cannot be grasped with a superficial glance. Such knowledge, put in plain words, is neither easily understood nor easily remembered:

"And its profound meaning is not easily remembered or understood. To explain it, one has to tell it in ordinary language, through ordinary examples."

This is the work of a symbol — **to bind a deep truth into ordinary language and everyday examples so that it can be remembered.**

Every Field Has Its Own Symbols

Acharya Ji explains that this method is not unique to religion; it happens in every discipline. Even in physics and chemistry:

"We write something symbolic, from which some new meaning emerges that belongs to everyday life, which helps me remember."

The same is true for medical students:

"Medical people too have something symbolic like that to remember the names of all the bones. To remember everything about the spinal cord there is something symbolic, and for the ribs too."

And drawing on his own engineering days, he says:

"So people in every field must have been given something like this. I told you about my mechanical one, from when I was doing engineering; computer people will have their own."

That is, a symbol is not knowledge in itself — it is a **support** for reaching knowledge and remembering it.

When the Symbol Becomes the Truth: The

Birth of Blind Faith

The purpose of a symbol is to remind us of the original meaning:

"So that form, meaning the symbolic — through the symbol in it, we have to remember what the formula's meaning actually was that we were meant to remember."

But if a wrong meaning is drawn from the symbol and we cling to it, what happens? Acharya Ji says clearly:

"If a different meaning altogether is drawn from that symbol or formula and we hold on to it, then **andhashraddhā** (blind faith) begins."

This is the most important warning of this discourse: **blind faith is not born of the symbol, but of clinging to a wrong meaning of the symbol.** When the means of remembering becomes the goal itself and its real pointer is forgotten, faith becomes blind.

Science and Religion: Exactly Opposite Arrangements

Acharya Ji then draws a beautiful comparison. In science, knowledge and symbol are arranged one way:

"So in a normal science book it is the reverse. In the book is the shastra, and the teacher has the symbolism."

That is, the science textbook contains the core principle, and the tricks for remembering it — the symbols — are given by the teacher. But in religion this arrangement is turned exactly upside down:

"And in our religions it is exactly the reverse — in the scripture everything is symbolic, and the teacher has the real knowledge and **anubhūti** (direct experience)."

Here the scripture speaks in symbols, and the real meaning of those symbols — **knowledge and direct experience** — lies with the Guru. That is why merely reading the scripture is not enough; an experienced Guru is needed to unlock its symbols.

Both Are Needed: The Symbol and the Real Knowledge

Should we then abandon symbols? No. Acharya Ji's conclusion is balanced:

"But both disciplines need both things. This much has settled in the mind — the symbol is needed, and the real knowledge is needed too. Both are needed."

Whether science or religion, **the symbol is the means of remembering, and the real knowledge is its essence.** One is incomplete without the other — hold only to the symbol and you get blind faith; keep only dry knowledge and it will not even be remembered.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1** **Profound knowledge needs symbols** — deep truth is understood and remembered only through ordinary language and ordinary examples.

- 2 **Every discipline uses symbols** — physics, chemistry, medicine, engineering all have symbolic devices for remembering.
- 3 **A symbol's job is to remind us of the original meaning** — the symbol is not the goal itself, but a pointer that leads to the goal.
- 4 **Blind faith is born of clinging to a wrong meaning of the symbol** — when a different meaning altogether is drawn from the symbol and held on to.
- 5 **Science and religion have opposite arrangements** — in science, the shastra is in the book and the symbols with the teacher; in religion, the symbols are in the scripture and the real knowledge and direct experience with the Guru.
- 6 **Both are needed** — the symbol and the real knowledge; this balance protects the seeker from blind faith and leads to truth.